From 1000 to 1824

Burma

Burman ethnic groups steadily gained more influence in central Burma, and by 1100 they had conquered the Mon. This led to emergence of the powerful Burmese Pagan Kingdom[24] and this was probably the first largely ethnic-Burman state in Myanmar. As a consequence, many later rulers have sought to trace their lineage to this era, so as to claim legitimacy in ruling over the whole of Burma. Even the military regimes of the past sixty years have been very keen to stress the importance of this period, and have invested substantially in rebuilding pagodas that dated from the Pagan era.[25]

The Pagan Kingdom unified the areas previously divided between the Mon and Pyu under the first king of the dynasty, Anawrahta (1044–77 AD). The new regime adopted Theravada Buddhism as the state religion, built a substantial number of religious buildings and also incorporated older animist deities into a Buddhist religious framework. The bulk of the population adopted Buddhism, but there was as yet no movement to exclude other religious beliefs prevalent in the region. There also seems to have been a great degree of cultural pluralism, and the Mon community in particular seems to have contributed substantially to cultural developments of the era.[26] By the late thirteenth century, the Pagan Kingdom was a major protector of Buddhism, constructing monasteries[27] and using its state power to ensure a coherent religious community emerged. However, this substantial expenditure on religious buildings, arts and monks may have undermined the economic basis of the kingdom.[28] A small Mongol incursion (part of a wider series of attacks into South East Asia from Vietnam to Thailand) in 1286 brought about the rapid collapse of the kingdom and its fragmentation into a number of smaller city states.

But though central Burma became a patchwork of smaller polities, most of the successor states sought to draw their legitimacy from the Pagan period. Equally, in terms of architecture and art, the process of moving from norms shared with India and regions to the east towards a more indigenous Burmese aesthetic continued. The Ava Kingdom (1287–1752) came to dominate upper Burma around Kyaukse. Over time this became the dominant power and managed to unify the Irrawaddy Valley by about 1636.